



Be Your Own Anti-Spyware

Bust troublemaking software and tweak your system with HijackThis

Nimish Chandiramani

Want more control over your computer's security? Or just want a more in-depth look at what's going on inside the box? HijackThis is an unassuming tool that hides the power to turn you into a human anti-spyware program! This program tells you all, but doesn't make any judgement—so it won't warn you if you're being plagued by adware/spyware/malware, but if you can identify the offending program, you can rid yourself of it permanently. Get it from <http://www.spywareinfo.com/~merijn/index.php>

You can also end up ridding yourself of some essential Windows services, so watching your step is advisable.

Scanning For Problems

At the HijackThis startup, the first thing you should do is a system scan. Saving a log file is optional, but a good idea when you're just starting out—you might need to show this log to someone else just to get a second opinion. Once you've done the scan, you're presented with a list of entries like "R0 - HKLM\Software\....." and so on. Here's what you should look out for in these entries:

Browser Helper Objects (BHOs, appear as O2 - BHO: [name] - {etc.}): These are the worst offenders. Any

toolbar that you install for IE is a BHO, and has effectively the same control over the computer as you. Malicious code writers usually use this category to wreak their havoc, so if you see something unfamiliar here, mark the checkbox next to it and click "Fix Checked" at the bottom.

Services (O23): Another favourite with malware authors is disguising their programs as NT services; you should make sure that you know the origin of each of these services. If it looks suspicious, Fix It!

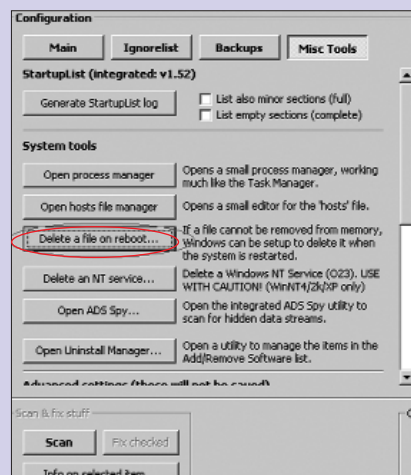
Note: Before fixing anything, make sure you're saving backups for those entries. On the bottom-right corner, click Config, and under the Main tab, make sure that the "Make backups before fixing items" checkbox is checked. It's on by default, but you should always double-check.

Restoring Backups

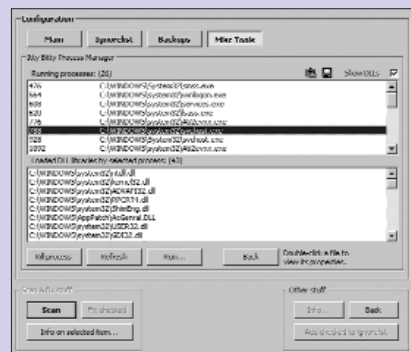
If you start experiencing problems with your system after you've used HijackThis, just restore the last backup you made. If you've just started the program, click on "Open the Misc. Tools Section" or Config if you've already run a scan. Under the Backups tab, you will see a list of backed-up items. Restore them one-by-one till your system runs fine again.

Delete Obnoxious Files

If you've found a malicious EXE that refuses to be End Tasked through the Windows Task Manager, in order to be able to delete it, salvation is at hand. Under the Misc. Tools tab in HijackThis, you'll find the "Delete a file on reboot" button—its function is quite self-explanatory. It's quite effective, especially if you're infected with a virus that refuses to let you even open the Task Manager. To get rid of malicious services, use "Delete an NT Service"; be careful when using this one, though.



Delete files that refuse to be deleted



The Process Manager is a more detailed Task Manager

Spy On Ads

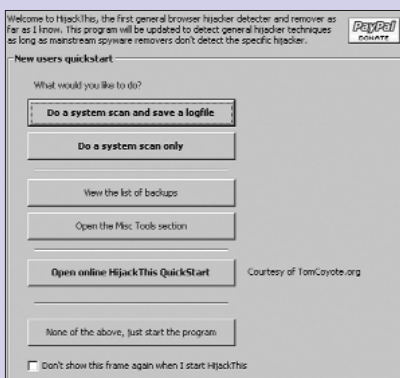
If you're worried about data being transmitted from your PC without your knowledge, use the ADS spy to scan your PC. It detects outgoing data from programs like keyloggers and other spyware that transmit your personal data to their parent sites.

Get The Low-down On Your PC

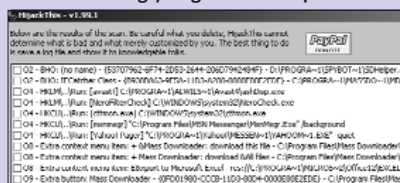
For a more advanced version of the Windows Task Manager, use the Process Manager from the Misc. Tools section. It also shows you which DLL files have been loaded by each program—tremendous value if you're doing this for academic interest.

Finally, if you're ever in doubt about making changes to your system with HijackThis, get some help—post your HijackThis log on a tech forum where more experienced people should be more than willing to assist you. ■

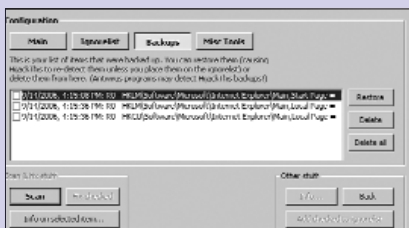
nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com



The first dialog you get at startup



What you're faced with after you do a system scan



Restore backups from the Backup section